“A loving God wouldn't let me suffer like this.”

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Where it often comes from

Pain makes God’s love hard to see. If He is all-powerful and loving, the logic seems to say He would stop it. Many faithful people have struggled with this tension.

What Scripture teaches

“My thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways My ways.” Habakkuk, Job, and the psalmists asked why. “Why, O LORD, do You stand far off?” God’s love is shown most clearly in the cross: “God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us.” “We do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses.” Not all questions have answers now, but God is with you, and suffering does not disprove love.

> *“But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us”* (Romans 5:8).

Also see

> “‘For My thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways My ways,’ declares the LORD. ‘For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so My ways are higher than your ways and My thoughts than your thoughts.’” (Isaiah 55:8–9).

> “Why, O LORD, do You stand far off? Why do You hide in times of trouble?” (Psalm 10:1).

> “For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses, but we have one who was tempted in every way that we are, yet was without sin” (Hebrews 4:15).

> “And we know that God works all things together for the good of those who love Him, who are called according to His purpose” (Romans 8:28).

Common self-statements

- If God loved me, He would stop it.
- He could help but does not.
- Love would not let this happen.
- Either He is not loving or not powerful.
- God has turned away.
- I do not understand His love.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing God is either loving or lets me suffer.
- Fortune telling: Predicting continued pain without God.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling pain and concluding that God does not love me.
- Labeling: Calling God unloving.

Challenging questions

- What exactly do I feel God has done or failed to do?
- Where did the psalmists take such questions?

- What did God do about suffering at the cross?
- Who has shown me God's love in this?
- What can I know even if I do not understand?
- What would it look like to bring this honestly to God?

Truth summary

> Suffering does not prove that God does not love me. His love was shown at the cross. I can ask my hardest questions, and He can bear them. I can trust Him even without all the answers.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Suffering
- God, All Loving
- Faith
- Hardship
- Hopeless

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Divorce
- Forgive/Forgiveness

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God's companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "A loving God wouldn't let me suffer like this"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"A loving God wouldn't let me suffer like this." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What exactly do I feel God has done or failed to do?
- ☐ Where did the psalmists take such questions?
- ☐ What did God do about suffering at the cross?
- ☐ Who has shown me God's love in this?
- ☐ What can I know even if I do not understand?
- ☐ What would it look like to bring this honestly to God?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God proved His love at the cross.
- ☐ Jesus sympathizes with my weakness.
- ☐ His ways are higher than mine.
- ☐ I can ask honest questions.
- ☐ He works for good.
- ☐ He is with me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Romans 5:8
  "But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us."
- ☐ Isaiah 55:8–9
  "'For My thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways My ways,' declares the LORD. 'For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so My ways are higher than your ways and My thoughts than your thoughts.'"
- ☐ Psalm 10:1
  "Why, O LORD, do You stand far off? Why do You hide in times of trouble?"

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Honest with God: Each week, write one honest prayer.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Romans 5:8 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God proved His love for me at the cross.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Suffering" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

These cards support emotional and spiritual care and do not replace medical care. Follow your doctor's advice about treatment and medication, and choose steps that are safe for your body. In an emergency call 911; for thoughts of self-harm call or text 988 (U.S.).

- [ ] Write your question. Tell God exactly what you think.
- [ ] Read Psalm 13 and 88. Notice the honesty.
- [ ] Talk to a pastor or friend. Share the struggle.
- [ ] Remember the cross. Read Romans 5:8 daily.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "A loving God wouldn't let me suffer like this": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Honest with God
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~A loving God wouldn't let me suffer like this.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I do not understand why. Hear my honest questions, show me Your love, and hold me until I see more. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.